INDIA’S FODDER EXPORTS AND THE GLOBAL FODDER MARKET

An analysis of Ministry of Commerce trade data (EIDB / DGCI&S), FY2017-18 to FY2025-26

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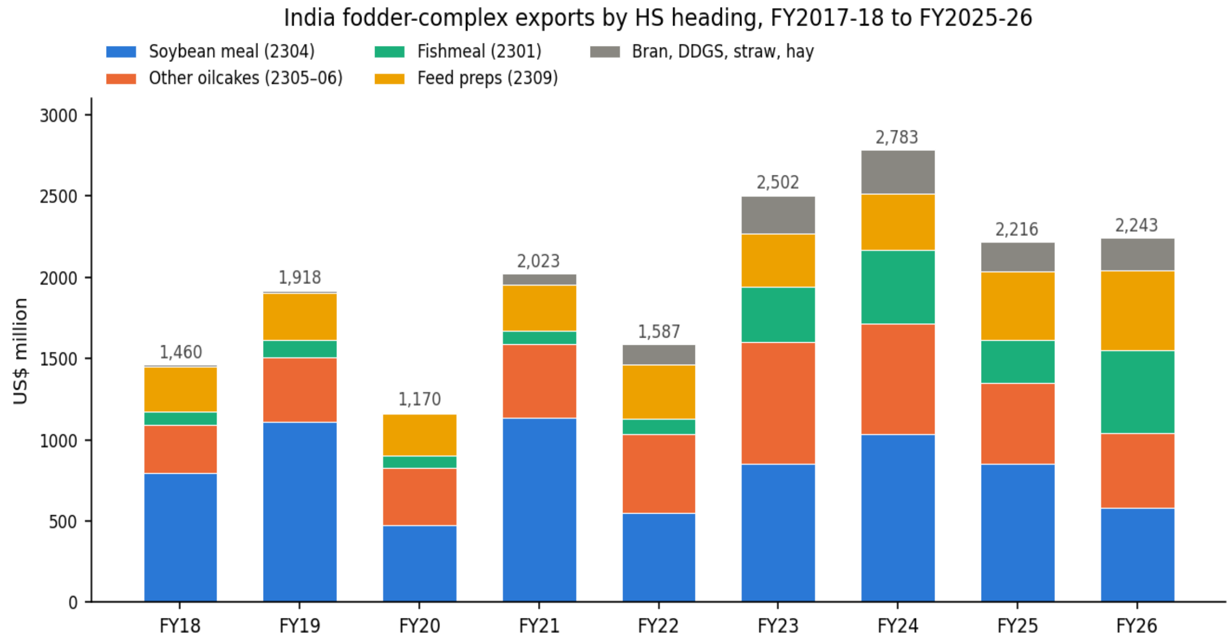
Executive summary

- **India exports almost no “fodder” in the conventional sense** — the commodities the world calls fodder (hay, alfalfa, forage, HS 1214) are a rounding error for India: $0.01M in FY25-26. India’s real fodder-complex export basket is oilseed meals, fishmeal and compound feed.
- **The fodder complex earned $2.24bn** in FY2025-26, essentially flat on FY24-25 ($2.22bn) and well below the FY23-24 peak of $2.78bn.
- **Beneath the flat total is a sharp composition shift**: commodity meals (soybean meal −32%, bran −58%) are being replaced by fishmeal (+88%), feed preparations (+18%) and DDGS (+58%) — higher-value, faster-growing lines.
- **Policy is the biggest variable on both sides**: the de-oiled rice bran export ban caps HS 2302, ethanol-blending policy feeds DDGS exports, and China’s restrictions on Canadian canola single-handedly revived Indian rapeseed meal.
- **The global hay/alfalfa trade is a separate arena**, dominated by the US, Australia, Canada and Spain selling to Japan, China, Korea and Saudi Arabia — a market India realistically will not enter given its own domestic green-fodder deficit.

1. The export series

Commodity-wise export values pulled from tradestat.commerce.gov.in (EIDB, 4-digit HS level). Financial years run April–March; FY26 = FY2025-26.

HS	Line	FY18	FY19	FY20	FY21	FY22	FY23	FY24	FY25	FY26
2304	Soybean meal	796	1,109	473	1,135	552	853	1,037	852	581
2301	Fishmeal / meat meal	83	106	76	86	94	336	453	269	508
2309	Feed preparations	273	291	256	283	339	332	348	419	495
2306	Other oilcakes (rapeseed etc.)	294	395	353	437	477	737	667	487	454
2303	DDGS, brewing dregs	5	8	3	15	8	26	83	105	166
2302	Bran (rice/wheat)	6	2	4	52	106	206	184	74	31
2305	Groundnut cake	3	5	2	14	3	12	10	9	5
1213	Cereal straw	0.3	1.1	1.7	1.3	3.5	0.2	0.2	0.8	2.0
1214	Hay, lucerne, forage	0.03	0.05	0.3	0.06	0.01	0.09	0.1	0.08	0.01
2308	Veg. waste for feed	0.2	0.3	0.3	0.2	4.2	0.8	0.8	0.6	0.1
	Fodder complex total	**1,460**	**1,916**	**1,170**	**2,022**	**1,587**	**2,503**	**2,783**	**2,216**	**2,243**



2. What is driving each line

2.1 Soybean meal (HS 2304) — structurally uncompetitive

India's largest fodder export line fell 32% to $581M in FY25-26. Indian FOB prices ran near $605/t against roughly $430/t CIF Rotterdam for South American meal. The Solvent Extractors' Association reports total oilmeal volumes fell 13% in FY25-26 (37.68 lakh t vs 43.42 lakh t), with Red Sea rerouting adding freight cost. The destination detail confirms a broad retreat: Germany $129M→$91M, France $84M→$50M, Belgium −82%. What remains is India's non-GMO premium niche (Germany, France, Japan, Korea) plus captive neighbours (Nepal, Bangladesh).

2.2 Rapeseed and other oilcakes (HS 2306) — rescued by China

Six-digit data shows the swing: exports to China jumped from $16M to $195M in one year, making it the top destination, after Beijing restricted Canadian canola. Meanwhile Bangladesh ($158M→$59M) and Korea ($122M→$51M) collapsed. The line now moves on China–Canada trade politics rather than Indian fundamentals — a concentration risk.

2.3 Fishmeal (HS 2301) — the boom story

At $508M, fishmeal exports are roughly six times their FY18 level and nearly doubled year-on-year. Growth is driven by aquaculture feed demand — China ($174M), Vietnam ($126M, tripled), Turkey ($56M) — and helped by India lifting long-standing restrictions on new fishmeal and fish-oil plant capacity. China, Vietnam and the US take around 62% of shipments.

2.4 Feed preparations (HS 2309) — the quiet compounder

The only line that grew in every year of the series (from $256M in FY20 to $495M in FY26). Destinations are well diversified — Bangladesh, Germany, Vietnam, US, Norway and Chile (salmon-feed inputs) — and pet food (HS 230910) is now $81M of it. This is the highest value-add, least volatile line in the basket.

2.5 Bran and DDGS (HS 2302 / 2303) — two sides of one policy

The de-oiled rice bran export ban (July 2023, since extended) took HS 2302 from $206M to $31M. Meanwhile the ethanol blending programme created a DDGS surplus that has become a $166M export line — and DDGS is also displacing soymeal in domestic feed rations, worsening the soymeal export surplus.

3. Top destinations, FY2025-26

US$ million; prior year (FY24-25) in parentheses.

Soybean meal (2304)	Rapeseed & other (2306)	Fishmeal (2301)	Feed preps (2309)
Germany — 91 (129)	China — 195 (16)	China — 174 (113)	Bangladesh — 90 (75)
Nepal — 69 (89)	Bangladesh — 59 (158)	Vietnam — 126 (40)	Germany — 33 (20)
Bangladesh — 51 (60)	Korea — 51 (122)	Turkey — 56 (9)	Nepal — 33 (33)
France — 50 (84)	Thailand — 48 (87)	Taiwan — 36 (34)	Vietnam — 31 (24)
Kenya — 45 (50)	Vietnam — 40 (48)	Japan — 25 (19)	USA — 29 (31)
UAE — 34 (43)	Indonesia — 11 (9)	Denmark — 23 (0)	Madagascar — 20 (17)

4. Global market context

- **Hay and alfalfa.** The global forage trade is dominated by the United States ($1.14bn hay exports in 2024, 3.2M t), Australia, Canada and Spain, selling to Japan (~$357M of US hay), China (~$330M), Korea and Saudi Arabia. The alfalfa hay market is estimated at roughly $101bn (2025) growing at ~6.6% CAGR. Hay is water-intensive, and India runs an 11–35% domestic green-fodder deficit — India is structurally absent from this market and likely to remain so.
- **Soybean meal.** Brazil (>30% of world exports) and Argentina set the global price. Argentina's export-tax cuts and a record Brazilian crop keep 2025/26 fundamentals bearish; Indian meal clears only where non-GMO status or freight differentials work in its favour.
- **Fishmeal and aquafeed.** A market projected at ~$22bn by 2035, with China forecast to take over half of world imports by 2034. This is the one global fodder segment where India is gaining structural share.

5. Takeaways

- India's fodder story is a composition shift, not growth: the FY26 total merely matched FY25, but commodity meals are being replaced by fishmeal, feed preps and DDGS.
- Three momentum lines worth monthly tracking (MEIDB): HS 2301, 2309 and 2303. Two headline-risk lines: HS 2304 (South American pricing) and HS 2306 (China policy).
- Watch policy calendars: the rice-bran export ban, ethanol blending targets, and China–Canada canola relations each move individual lines by $100M+ per year.

Sources

- Ministry of Commerce & Industry, tradestat.commerce.gov.in — EIDB commodity-wise and commodity-by-country export tables (all India trade figures; pulled 23 Jul 2026).
- Solvent Extractors' Association of India (via Rural Voice, Kedia Advisory, Business Standard) — FY2025-26 oilmeal volumes and price competitiveness.
- Globoil India Intelligence — "The Meal Reversal", FY26 oilmeal export analysis.
- USDA FAS — forage and hay export data; grains and oilseeds outlook 2025/26.
- Mordor Intelligence, Precedence Research, Tridge, Volza, AgNavigator — global alfalfa hay, fishmeal and marine-ingredients market estimates.